

Lecture Notes for Math 243: Calculus III

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0 Tentative Course Outline

- **Weeks 1-3:** Parametric equations and Polar coordinates
 1. Arc length
 2. Curves defined by parametric equations.
 3. Calculus with plane curves.
 4. Polar coordinates
 5. Areas and lengths in polar coordinates
 6. Conic sections.
- **Weeks 4-6:** Vectors and the geometry of space.
 1. Three-dimensional coordinate systems.
 2. Vectors.
 3. The dot product.
 4. The cross product.
 5. Equations of lines and planes.
 6. Cylinders and quadric surfaces.
- **Friday, October 16 (week 8):** Midterm exam
- **Weeks 7-9:** Vector functions.
 1. Vector functions and space curves
 2. Derivatives and integrals of vector functions.
 3. Arc length and curvature.
 4. Motion in space: velocity and acceleration.
- **Weeks 10-16:** Partial derivatives.
 1. Functions of several variables.
 2. Limits and continuity
 3. Partial derivatives.
 4. Tangent planes and linear approximations
 5. The chain rule.
 6. Directional derivatives and the gradient vector.
 7. Maximum and minimum values.
 8. Discovery project (p.1010 Stewart): Quadratic approximation and critical points (Taylors formula for two variables).
 9. Lagrange multipliers.
- **Monday, December 14:** Final exam.

1 2026-08-24 | Week 01 | Lecture 01

This lecture is based on textbook section 6.3. “Arc length”

The nexus question of this lecture: How do we compute the length of a curve, assuming the curve is the graph of a function?

1.1 Arc Length

First, recall the definition of **derivative**:

$$f'(x) := \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h}$$

or equivalently,

$$f'(x) = \lim_{\tilde{x} \rightarrow x} \frac{f(\tilde{x}) - f(x)}{\tilde{x} - x}$$

In other words, the derivative is obtained by computing

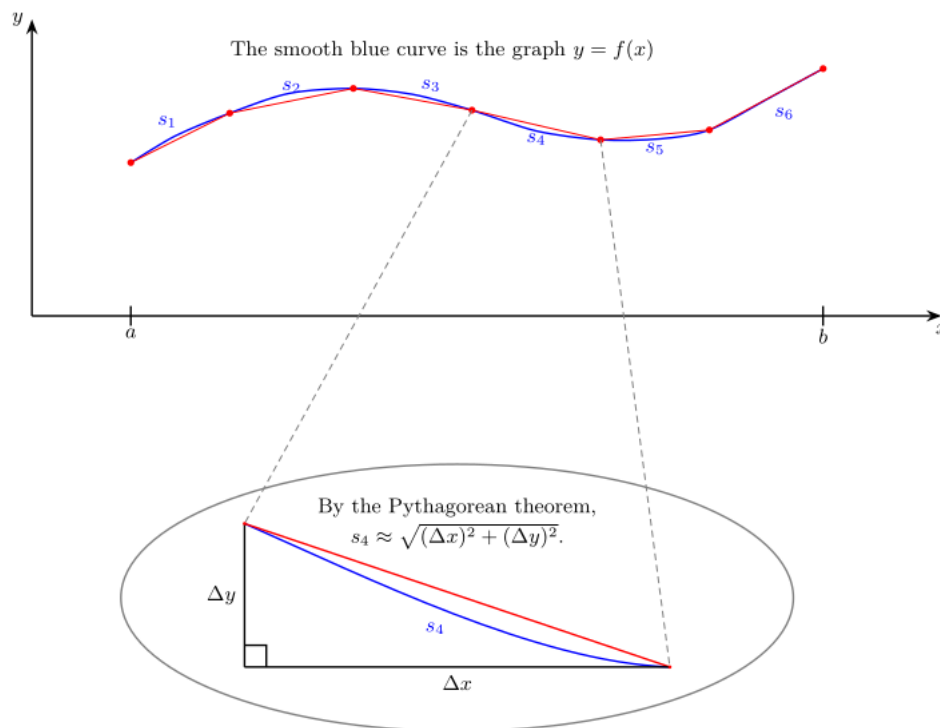
$$\frac{\text{change in } y\text{-value}}{\text{change in } x\text{-value}} = \frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}$$

as $\Delta x \rightarrow 0$.

One of the central ideas in calculus is to approximate curvy things with flat things. For example, if faced with a curve, approximate it with straight lines. For example,

Problem: I am an ant, and I want to travel from a to b by walking on the graph of $f(x)$. How far must I walk?

Strategy: Cheat a little: think of the ant walking in a bunch of straight lines that are pretty close to the curve.



In this example, the length of the curve $y = f(x)$ from $x = a$ to $x = b$ can be decomposed as

$$(\text{Arc Length}) = s_1 + s_2 + \dots + s_6,$$

where

$$s_i = (\text{length of segment } i)$$

Each segment length can be approximated by a straight line. For example,

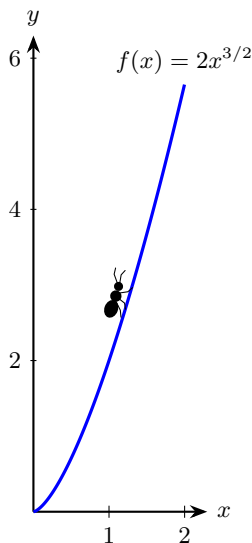
$$\begin{aligned} s_4 &\approx \sqrt{(\Delta x)^2 + (\Delta y)^2} && \text{since the line segment length approximates the curve length} \\ &= \sqrt{\left[1 + \left(\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}\right)^2\right] (\Delta x)^2} \\ &= \sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}\right)^2} \Delta x \\ &\approx \sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{dy}{dx}\right)^2} dx && \text{this holds when } \Delta x \approx 0, \text{ so long as the curve is smooth} \\ &= \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx && \text{by change of notation} \end{aligned}$$

This example motivates the following theorem.

Theorem 1 (Arc length formula). *Let f be a differentiable function on the interval $[a, b]$, and assume that f' is continuous on $[a, b]$. Then the arc length of f from $x = a$ to $x = b$ is*

$$(\text{Arc Length}) = \int_a^b \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx$$

Example 2 (Arc length). Find the length of the curve defined by $f(x) = 2x^{3/2}$, where x ranges from $x = 0$ to $x = 2$.



Solution: $f'(x) = 3x^{\frac{1}{2}}$, so

$$\begin{aligned} (\text{Arc length}) &= \int_0^2 \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx \\ &= \int_0^2 \sqrt{1 + 9x} dx \end{aligned}$$

which we can solve with a u -substitution, taking $u = 1 + 9x$. Doing this gives a length of about 6.06.

End of Example 2. $\square$

The **hyperbolic cosine** and **hyperbolic sine** functions are defined as

$$\cosh(x) := \frac{e^x + e^{-x}}{2}, \quad \sinh(x) := \frac{e^x - e^{-x}}{2}.$$

These two functions are “nice” in that they behave in some respects similarly to the standard sine and cosine functions; in particular, $\cosh$ is an even function (like $\cos(x)$) and $\sinh(x)$ is odd (like $\sin(x)$).

One can check they satisfy:

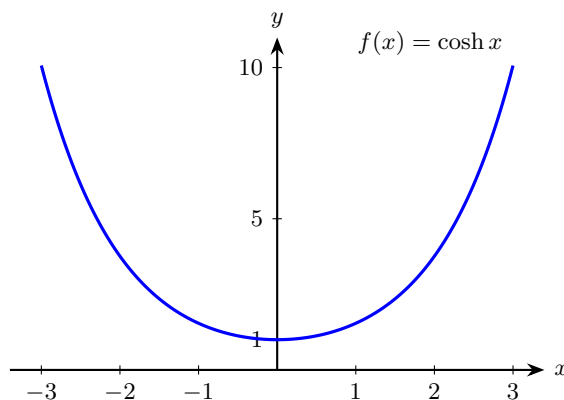
$$\cosh'(x) = \sinh(x), \quad \sinh'(x) = \cosh(x). \quad (1)$$

Also, we have the following identity:

$$\cosh^2(x) - \sinh^2(x) = 1. \quad (2)$$

A hanging chain forms a curve known as a **catenary**. The general formula of a catenary is a function involving hyperbolic cosine; in the next example, we'll consider the simplest case.

Example 3 (Arc length). Suppose $f(x) = \cosh(x)$ represents a chain from two endpoints at $x = -3$ and $x = 3$. Find the length of the chain.



$$\begin{aligned} \text{(length of chain)} &= \int_{-3}^3 \sqrt{1 + [\cosh'(x)]^2} dx \\ &= \int_{-3}^3 \sqrt{1 + \sinh^2(x)} dx && \text{since } \cosh'(x) = \sinh(x) \text{ by Eq. (1)} \\ &= \int_{-3}^3 \sqrt{\cosh^2(x)} dx && \text{by Eq. (2)} \\ &= \int_{-3}^3 \cosh(x) dx && \text{since } \cosh(x) > 0 \text{ for all } x \in \mathbb{R} \\ &= [\sinh(x)]_{x=-3}^{x=3} && \text{since } \sinh'(x) = \cosh(x) \text{ Eq. (1)} \\ &= \sinh(3) - \sinh(-3) \\ &\approx 20.036 \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 3. $\square$

Tips

- Check that your answer is positive. Arc length is never negative.
- These problems are usually contrived so that you can actually do the integral. If the integral looks too hard, double check your work. Also, there might be a trick to the integral.

2 2026-08-26 | Week 01 | Lecture 02

This lecture is based on textbook section 6.3 “Arc Length”, and section 11.1 “Parametric Equations and Polar Coordinates”. Please read 6.3 and begin start reading 11.1.

Example 4 (Warm up problem: Chain rule practice). Find the derviative of

$$f(x) = \log\left(\frac{x^2}{\sin x}\right).$$

Solution:

$$\begin{aligned} f'(x) &= \frac{d}{dx} \left[\log\left(\frac{x^2}{\sin x}\right) \right] \\ &= \frac{\sin x}{x^2} \frac{d}{dx} \left[\frac{x^2}{\sin x} \right] && \text{by the chain rule} \\ &= \frac{\sin x}{x^2} \left(\frac{2x \sin x - x^2 \cos x}{(\sin x)^2} \right) && \text{by the quotient rule} \\ &= \frac{2}{x} - \cot x && \text{after simplification.} \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 4. $\square$

2.1 Arc length - examples

Example 5 (Arc length). **Problem:** Let

$$f(x) = \frac{x^3}{3} + \frac{1}{4x} + 7,$$

for $1 \leq x \leq 2$. earlier examples.

(*Hint:* This problem is similar to Theorem 3.)

Solution: We want to apply Theorem 1. To do this, we first compute $1 + [f'(x)]^2$:

$$\begin{aligned} 1 + [f'(x)]^2 &= 1 + \left(x^2 - \frac{1}{4}x^{-2}\right)^2 \\ &= x^4 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{16}x^{-4} \\ &= \left(x^2 + \frac{1}{4}x^{-2}\right)^2. \end{aligned}$$

The last step, where we write the equation as a perfect square, is kinda hard to see. But since we're familiar with Theorem 3, we know to possibly expect something like that.

Now, we can apply the formul from Theorem 1:

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{Arc Length} &= \int_1^2 \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx \\
 &= \int_1^2 \sqrt{\left(x^2 + \frac{1}{4}x^{-2}\right)^2} dx \\
 &= \int_1^2 x^2 + \frac{1}{4}x^{-2} dx \\
 &= \left[\frac{x^3}{3} - \frac{1}{4}x^{-1}\right]_1^2 \\
 &= \left(\frac{8}{3} - \frac{1}{8}\right) - \left(\frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{4}\right) \\
 &\approx 2.46.
 \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 5. $\square$

Example 6. Find the arc length of

$$f(x) = \frac{x^3}{12} + x^{-1}, \quad 1 \leq x \leq 4$$

Solution: For the complete solution, see Example 2 in section 6.3 of the textbook. We sketch the approach here.

The key step is to factor

$$\begin{aligned}
 1 + [f'(x)]^2 &= \frac{x^4}{16} + \frac{1}{2} + x^{-4} \\
 &= \left(\frac{x^2}{4} + x^{-2}\right)^2
 \end{aligned}$$

The arc length integral then reduces to

$$\int_1^4 \left(\frac{x^2}{4} + x^{-2}\right) dx$$

which evaluates to 6.

End of Example 6. $\square$

2.2 Introduction to parametric equations

This section is based on chapter 11.1 in the textbook.

I am an ant walking around the whiteboard, and I'm covered in ink. My path is described in the following way:

- The variable t measures time. We start at $t = 0$ and end at time $t = T_{\text{end}} > 0$.
- At each moment in time t , the number $x(t)$ represents my x -coordinate
- And the number $y(t)$ represents my y -coordinate.

The **parametric equation** is the picture I draw by walking around the whiteboard.

Definition 7 (Parametric Equations and Curves). Let I be an interval, and let $f : I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and $g : I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous functions whose domain is I . The set of all points of the form

$$(x, y) = (f(t), g(t))$$

as t varies over I , is the **graph** of the **parametric equations** $x = f(t)$ and $y = g(t)$. Here, t is called the **parameter**. A **curve** is a graph along with the parametric equations that define it.

Notation 8. In “set-builder notation,” the graph of the parametric equations $x = f(t)$ and $y = g(t)$ is the set

$$\{(f(t), g(t)) : t \in I\}.$$

For those unfamiliar with this notation: the colon ‘:’ is read as “such that” and ‘ $\in$ ’ is an abbreviation of “is an element of”

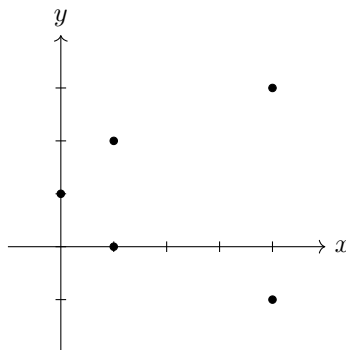
Example 9 (Plotting parametric functions). Plot the graph of the parametric equations

$$\begin{cases} x = t^2 \\ y = t + 1 \end{cases}$$

for t in $I = [-2, 2]$.

Solution: Start by plotting some points by making a table.

t	$x = t^2$	$y = t + 1$
-2	4	-1
-1	1	0
0	0	1
1	1	2
2	4	3



Then we can draw a curve through the points. (Not shown).

If we replace $I = [-2, 2]$ by $I = \mathbb{R}$, then this corresponding graph would trace out a sideways opening parabola defined by the equation $x = (y - 1)^2$.

Question: can we write y a function of x ?

No! No, because the graph doesn’t satisfy the vertical line test.

Question: can we express this as an equation involving only x and y ?

Yes! $x = (y - 1)^2$.

End of Example 9. $\square$